



MINDFULNESS ON THE MATS™

MAKK–MOTM™ Parent Workshop

Instructor Guide — 35 Minutes

Helping parents understand and reinforce the MOTM™ curriculum at home.

Children perform better when parents understand what they're learning.
This workshop gives parents the language, the tools, and the experience.

Program Overview

Purpose: To give parents a working understanding of the Mindfulness on the Mats™ curriculum so the skills their children are building in class can be recognized and reinforced at home.

Detail	Specification
Format	35-minute parent-facing instructor-led workshop
Audience	Parents and guardians of enrolled students
Setting	Conversational — no projector required
Key Outcome	Parents leave with language, tools, and lived experience of the curriculum

IMPORTANT DISCLAIMER

This is NOT therapy. Mindfulness on the Mats™ is an educational skills program. We teach attention, breathing, and self-regulation — the same way we teach a kata. This program does not replace professional mental health counseling.

AT A GLANCE · CLASS TIMELINE

At a Glance — Class Timeline

Time	Segment	Format
0:00 – 3:00	Welcome and Opening	Talk
3:00 – 13:00	What Is Mindfulness? The Four Pillars	Presentation
13:00 – 18:00	The Science: Why This Works	Presentation
18:00 – 26:00	Breathing Practice — The Tactical Breath	Guided Exercise
26:00 – 35:00	Reinforcing Skills at Home + Q&A;	Discussion

SEGMENT 1

Welcome and Opening

0:00 – 3:00 | 3 min

Setup: Parents seated. Keep it warm and casual. No screen needed — this class is conversational.

“Thank you for being here. This is not a typical school presentation. We’re not going to just talk at you — we’re actually going to do some of this work together tonight.”

“Your child has been learning something in class called Mindfulness on the Mats™. Over the next 35 minutes, you’re going to understand exactly what that means, experience one of the key tools yourself, and walk out of here with a few simple ways to reinforce these skills at home.”

“You don’t need to know anything about mindfulness. You don’t need to be a meditator. If you’ve never tried this before — perfect. You’ll have the same starting point your child had on their first day.”

“One important note before we begin: This is not therapy. Mindfulness on the Mats™ is an educational skills program. We are teaching attention, breathing, and self-regulation — the same way we teach a kata or a combination. If you or your child are working through something that needs professional support, we always encourage you to seek that out. This program is not a substitute for it.”

SEGMENT 2

What Is Mindfulness? The Four Pillars

3:00 – 13:00 | 10 min

“Here’s the simplest definition I know: Mindfulness is paying attention — on purpose — to what is happening right now. Not yesterday. Not tomorrow. Right here, right now.”

“The ancient martial arts masters trained this as a core discipline — total, present awareness of yourself and everything around you. It’s not a new concept. Martial artists have been developing this for thousands of years. We’ve simply built a structured curriculum around it.”

“Here’s the practical version. Think about a time your child got so frustrated they said something they didn’t mean. Or froze under pressure. Or couldn’t focus when it mattered most. That’s not a personality flaw. That’s an untrained mind. And just like an untrained body — we can change it.”

“The curriculum moves through four pillars over four months, then cycles again — going deeper each time. Let me walk you through what your child is learning in each one.”

Pillar 1 — Breath**Month 1**

“The first month is entirely about breath. How we breathe directly controls how our nervous system responds to stress — and breath is the one tool we always have access to, instantly, anywhere, with no equipment.”

“Your child is learning belly breathing, box breathing, the Warrior’s Bellows for energy and focus, and a cool-down breath for when emotions are running hot. When your child comes home and says they need to do their breathing, encourage it. Better yet — do it with them.”

Pillar 2 — Body**Month 2**

“Month two shifts to body awareness. We carry tension in our bodies without realizing it — in the jaw, the shoulders, the hands. Body awareness teaches students to find where they hold stress and release it before it slows them down.”

“We use an exercise called the Iron Root, where students visualize being grounded and stable. We also work on the difference between tension and readiness — because a tense body is a slow body. A ready body is a fast one.”

“You can support this at home simply by asking: Where are you holding tension right now? You may be surprised — they can usually tell you.”

Pillar 3 — Mind**Month 3**

“Month three is about mental focus. We practice the ability to let distracting thoughts pass without chasing them — the way you watch clouds move across the sky without grabbing on.”

“We also teach students how to reset mentally after a mistake, rather than getting stuck in it. This directly applies to test anxiety, social pressure, and performance under stress. If your child starts saying things like ‘I’m trying to let the thought go’ or ‘I need to reset’ — that’s this.”

Pillar 4 — Spirit**Month 4**

“The fourth month brings everything together. We work on flow state — the feeling of being fully absorbed and performing without hesitation. We explore what motivates your child at their core — why they train, what it means to them. And we practice self-compassion — the ability to recover after a mistake without spiraling.”

“That last piece is one of the most important things we teach. Perfectionism and fear of failure are real obstacles for kids in martial arts and in life. We teach them that falling down is part of training. Getting stuck there is the only real failure.”

TIP FOR PARENTS

When your child comes home and uses this language — “I need to do my breathing,” “I’m trying to let the thought go,” “I need to reset” — take it seriously. Ask them to show you. When a child teaches something, they own it twice as deeply.

SEGMENT 3

The Science: Why This Works*Keep this simple. One core concept, clearly stated. No jargon.***13:00 – 18:00 | 5 min**

“Here’s what’s actually happening in your child’s brain when they do this work.”

“There are two parts of the brain we care about. The first is the amygdala — think of it as the brain’s alarm system. It fires when we feel threatened, embarrassed, overwhelmed, or angry. When the amygdala takes over, the thinking brain goes offline. That’s why kids — and adults — say and do things they instantly regret. The amygdala grabbed the wheel.”

“The second part is the prefrontal cortex — the thinking brain. Decision-making. Impulse control. Empathy. This is where we want kids operating from.”

“The breath is the bridge between the two. A slow, controlled exhale activates what’s called the parasympathetic nervous system — the body’s rest-and-reset response. Heart rate drops. Stress hormones drop. The alarm quiets. The thinking brain comes back online.”

“That’s not philosophy. That’s physiology. And it’s trainable — the same way a kick or a punch is trainable.”

“What we’re building is called self-regulation. Children who develop this skill early perform better academically, handle social pressure better, and are significantly more resilient under stress. This is some of the most well-supported research in developmental psychology.”

“Now that you understand why it works — let’s actually do it.”

The Amygdala	The Prefrontal Cortex
The brain’s alarm system. Fires under threat, embarrassment, or overwhelm. When it takes over, the thinking brain goes offline.	The thinking brain. Decision-making, impulse control, empathy. This is where we want students operating from.
The breath is the bridge. A long exhale activates the parasympathetic response — heart rate drops, stress hormones drop, the alarm quiets.	The goal of this curriculum is to make the path from alarm to reset faster, more automatic, and available under real pressure.

SEGMENT 4

Breathing Practice: The Tactical Breath

18:00 – 26:00 | 8 min

*Do not skip this. Parents leave having experienced the tool — not just heard about it.***INSTRUCTOR NOTE**

This is the same exercise your students are doing in class. Deliver it slowly and breathe with the group. The debrief at the end is as important as the exercise itself.

Setup — Say This Before You Begin

“We’re going to do a breathing exercise together right now. I want you to actually try it — not just observe. If at any point you feel uncomfortable, you are completely in control. Open your eyes, put your feet on the floor, take a break. That is always an option.”

“This is called Box Breathing — four counts in, four counts hold, four counts out, four counts hold. We teach this to your children as the Tactical Breath, because knowing how to reset under pressure is a skill. Now you’re going to feel what they feel.”

Guided Script — Deliver Slowly

“Sit comfortably. Both feet flat on the floor. Hands resting in your lap. You can close your eyes, or soften your gaze toward the floor — whatever feels right.”

“Take one natural breath in and let it go. Don’t force anything yet.”

[Breathe with them for one natural breath.]

“Now — Inhale through your nose. Nice and slow. One... two... three... four.”

[Count silently — 4 seconds.]

“Hold at the top. One... two... three... four. Don’t strain. Just hold.”

[Count silently — 4 seconds.]

“Exhale slowly through your mouth. One... two... three... four. Let everything go.”

[Count silently — 4 seconds.]

“Hold the empty. One... two... three... four. Your body knows what to do.”

[Count silently — 4 seconds.]

[Repeat the full cycle 3–4 more times in silence. Breathe with them. Don’t speak during cycles.]

“Begin to bring your attention back to the room. Take one natural breath. When you’re ready, open your eyes.”

Debrief — 1 Minute

“What did you notice? Did anything shift, even slightly?”

[Take 2–3 brief responses.]

“That small shift — that’s what we’re building in your child, every single class. With repetition, they stop having to think about it. The reset becomes automatic.”

“If you or your child need a deeper sense of calm — not just focus, but actual de-escalation — make the exhale longer than the inhale. Breathe in for four, breathe out for six or eight. A longer exhale sends a stronger signal to the nervous system that it’s safe to settle down. That’s a useful tool in a real moment.”

“And when your child is struggling — whether they have their eyes open or closed — get down to their level. Physically. Get on your knees if you need to. Let them hear you breathing. You don’t have to say anything. Just breathe with them, audibly, until they start to match you. That co-regulation is one of the most powerful things a parent can do.”

SEGMENT 5

Reinforcing Skills at Home + Q&A

26:00 – 35:00 | 9 min

“Here are three concrete things you can do at home that take almost no time and make a significant difference.”

#	Strategy	What It Looks Like
1	Take the language seriously.	When you hear your child say “I need to reset,” “I’m trying to let the thought go,” or “I need my breathing” — don’t dismiss it. Ask them to show you. When a child teaches something, they own it twice as deeply.
2	Do the breath together.	Pick one regular moment — before bed, before homework, before a big game or test. The goal is that the Tactical Breath becomes a household tool, not just a school thing. For younger children: use “smell the flower” on the inhale and “blow out the candle” on the exhale. That’s the language they know.
3	Ask the right question.	Instead of “How was class?” try: “What did you practice in your mind today?” “Did anything come up that was hard to stay focused through?” “Did you use your breathing today?” These questions communicate that the mental work is as real and as valued as the physical work.

Closing

“The goal of this program is not to make your child a meditator. It’s to give them a set of skills that make them more effective — in competition, at school, in relationships, and eventually in whatever life puts in front of them.”

“You are the most important part of that equation. When skills get reinforced at home, they stop being something a child does in class and become part of who they are.”

“Thank you for being here tonight. Any questions?”

[Open for Q&A; — remaining time.]

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